AN ORIGINAL NIGERIAN DRAMA

The Wrong Number

She texted a dead number... and a stranger answered.

Abuja. A doctor's wife who can't remember whether her husband wants jollof or fried rice, and is terrified of guessing wrong. Lagos. A grieving journalist who wasn't supposed to wake up that morning. One wrong text. Two women saving each other. And a husband who reads every message.



53	~54	100%	3
SCENES	MINUTES	DIALOGUE	ACTS

The cast

CHLOE ADEYEMI
(33 → 43). Beautiful and gifted, a trained interior designer. Married to Kunle with two children, living in Abuja. She has learned to say "sorry" before she even knows what she did. → first appears in Scene 1

DR. KUNLE ADEYEMI
(40). Medical Director of Adeyemi Specialist Hospital, Maitama. Charming in public and controlling at home. He believes a husband owns his house, his car and his wife. → first appears in Scene 1

EMMA WILLIAMS
(35 → 45). Journalist at The Lagos Herald, a newspaper in Ikeja, for ten years: underpaid, overworked and never credited. Witty and blunt on the outside. Three months ago her younger sister Ronke died of cancer, and Emma is drowning in grief she shows no one. After the funeral she bought a new SIM card, and nobody told her the number used to belong to someone else. → first appears in Scene 11

ADA
(7). Chloe's daughter, who notices everything. TOBI (4), her son. → first appears in Scene 1

MUSA
The family driver. → first appears in Scene 2

RITA
Kunle's secretary at the hospital. → first appears in Scene 3

NKEM
Kunle's girlfriend. → first appears in Scene 9

MAMA KUNLE
Kunle's mother. → first appears in Scene 7

HALIMA
Chloe's old university friend. → first appears in Scene 19

BISI
Emma's colleague at the Herald and her best friend. → first appears in Scene 14

MR. BAYO ADEKOLA
Editor of The Lagos Herald. A bully who takes credit for Emma's work.

MRS. FOLAKE DARAMOLA
The Herald's new Managing Director.

DR. IFEOMA
A doctor and counsellor in Lagos. → first appears in Scene 21

RONKE
(seen in a photo and heard in voice notes). Emma's late sister. → first appears in Scene 11

BARRISTER ZAINAB BELLO
Chloe's lawyer.

TUNDE BALOGUN
An architect, gentle and patient.

MR. OKORO
Kunle's lawyer. → first appears in Scene 38

JUDGE
, GUESTS, CLIENT, SECURITY GUARD, MC. → first appears in Scene 38

Follow a story thread

Tap a scene number to jump straight to it.

The Rice

The humiliation that starts everything, and where it comes back.

SCENE 4 SCENE 5 SCENE 6 SCENE 38 SCENE 40

Emma's Darkest Night

Ronke, the voice note, and the text that arrived the afternoon she woke up.

SCENE 11 SCENE 12 SCENE 14 SCENE 26

The Dead Number

How a thrown-away SIM reached a grieving stranger in Lagos.

SCENE 8 SCENE 9 SCENE 10 SCENE 12 SCENE 14

Two Women Saving Each Other

Halima and Dr. Ifeoma: each one sends the other to get help.

SCENE 18 SCENE 19 SCENE 20 SCENE 21 SCENE 44

Emma's Fight at the Herald

The binned story, ten unpaid years and the new boss.

SCENE 20 SCENE 43 SCENE 45

The Deleted Chat

Kunle reads her phone, and the month of silence.

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Emma Stands Her Ground

The phone call, the ticket and the newsroom lobby.

SCENE 31 SCENE 32 SCENE 33

Justice

The night she left, the witness, his mother, his daughter and the white coat.

SCENE 34 SCENE 36 SCENE 38 SCENE 39 SCENE 41

Ten Years of Fridays

From the first Friday to the empty chair to "Still here."

SCENE 15 SCENE 17 SCENE 49 SCENE 51 SCENE 52 SCENE 53

How to use this PDF

- Tap any scene in the contents, or any scene number in a thread, to jump to it. Your PDF app's bookmarks list every scene too.
- Every scene has ◀ **Previous**, **All scenes** and **Next** ▶ links at the top.
- Text messages appear as chat bubbles: Chloe on the right in green, everyone else on the left. A red bubble means someone is typing as somebody else.
- Every scene has three **production checkboxes** (Images, Voice, Edited). Tick them as you make the video. They save with the PDF in most PDF apps.

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ACT ONE

The Rice

SCENE 1 OF 53 · 0:00–0:58

The Food Must Not Be Late

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION, ASOKORO, ABUJA — KITCHEN — FRIDAY, 12:41 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A huge marble kitchen. Three pots are on the fire. CHLOE ADEYEMI (33), beautiful and sweating, stirs one pot while holding her phone to her ear with her shoulder. TOBI (4) cries from the sitting room. ADA (7), in her school uniform, pulls her wrapper.*

KUNLE (ON PHONE) Chloe. It's 12:41.

CHLOE I know, darling. The stew is almost—

KUNLE (ON PHONE) I didn't ask about the stew. I said my food should be on my desk by one o'clock. I have the board meeting at half past one. Do you want me to collapse in front of my board?

CHLOE No, darling. It will be there. I promise.

KUNLE (ON PHONE) Your promises are like NEPA light, Chloe. They come and go.

> *He hangs up. Chloe stares at the phone.*

ADA Mummy, Tobi poured Milo on the rug.

CHLOE *(closing her eyes)* Okay. Okay. Mummy is coming.

ADA Why can't Aunty Blessing help us? She used to help us.

CHLOE Because Daddy said nobody touches his children except their mother. *(beat)* Go and wash Tobi's hands, my love.

> *She grabs a food flask, the cooler and her phone, and dials.*

SCENE 2 OF 53 · 0:58–2:01

"Please Madam, Don't Touch the Car"

INT. KITCHEN / EXT. FUEL STATION, WUSE — INTERCUT — 12:48 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *MUSA, the family driver, stands beside the black Lexus at a fuel queue that stretches out of sight.*

CHLOE Musa, where are you? I need you to take me to Oga's office now now. His food must be there by one.

MUSA (ON PHONE) Ah, madam! I'm at Wuse. Oga sent me money this morning to buy fuel for the week. The queue is long like Third Mainland Bridge. I'll be there in thirty minutes, madam.

CHLOE Thirty minutes? Musa, I don't have thirty minutes. He'll kill me.

MUSA (ON PHONE) Madam, please wait for me. Please.

> *Chloe looks at the wall, where the spare key to Kunle's other car, the white Range Rover, hangs on a hook.*

CHLOE I'll drive myself.

MUSA (ON PHONE) *(panicking)* Madam, NO! Please, madam, don't touch Oga's car! You know how Oga is about that car! Madam, I'm begging you, wait for me—

> *Chloe hangs up. Her hand shakes as she takes the key off the hook.*

ADA *(at the door)* Mummy, are you allowed to drive Daddy's car?

CHLOE *(forcing a smile)* Today, Mummy is allowed. Look after your brother. Mummy will be back in one hour.

SCENE 3 OF 53 · 2:01–2:45

The Speech

INT. ADEYEMI SPECIALIST HOSPITAL, MAITAMA — BOARDROOM / RECEPTION — 1:06 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *BOARDROOM. Twelve doctors and board members listen while DR. KUNLE ADEYEMI (40), handsome and in a perfect suit, gives a speech. Applause is building.*

KUNLE …and this is why our hospital is different. We don't only treat bodies. We treat families. Compassion. Patience. Respect. That is the Adeyemi standard. *(beat)* A man who cannot be gentle with the weak has no business wearing a white coat.

> *Applause.*

> *RECEPTION. Chloe hurries in with the cooler, out of breath. RITA, the secretary, looks up.*

RITA Good afternoon, ma. Mrs. Adeyemi?

CHLOE Good afternoon. Please, I've brought my husband's lunch. Is he—

RITA He's in the board meeting, ma. Please sit down. I'll tell Dr. Kunle the moment he comes out.

> *Chloe sits on a leather sofa and holds the cooler on her lap like a baby. A TV on the wall plays a cooking show. The host laughs: "And remember, ladies, a happy kitchen is a happy home!" Chloe watches it without blinking.*

SCENE 4 OF 53 · 2:45–3:47

"Who Brought You Here?"

INT. KUNLE'S OFFICE — 1:31 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A big office with diplomas on the wall. Kunle sits down, loosening his tie. Rita knocks and enters.*

RITA Good afternoon, sir. Your wife is in reception.

KUNLE *(surprised, then smiling)* My wife? Call her inside.

> *Chloe enters with the cooler and a nervous smile.*

CHLOE I brought your food, darling. It's still hot.

KUNLE *(not touching it)* What are you doing here?

CHLOE You said your food should be on your desk by one—

KUNLE Who brought you here?

CHLOE …I came.

KUNLE Where is Musa?

CHLOE He went to buy fuel. You sent him the money this morning. He said thirty minutes, and I knew you were hungry, so—

> *Kunle stands slowly. He walks to the window and looks down at the car park. His white Range Rover is parked crookedly across two spaces.*

KUNLE *(very quietly)* You touched my car.

CHLOE Darling, I only—

KUNLE What did I tell you about my car, Chloe? *(beat)* What did I TELL you?

CHLOE *(whispering)* Not to drive it.

> *Rita stands frozen by the door. Kunle opens the cooler and lifts out the steaming food flask. Then he pours the jollof rice over Chloe's head. It runs down her hair, her face and her dress. Rita gasps and covers her mouth.*

KUNLE *(calmly)* Now you're hot too. *(beat)* Get out of my office.

> *Chloe stands there, rice falling from her hair onto the carpet. She can't breathe.*

KUNLE Rita, call the cleaners. *(to Chloe)* And give Rita my car key. Musa will bring it home.

> *Chloe puts the key on the desk with a shaking hand and walks out past Rita, who can't look at her.*

SCENE 5 OF 53 · 3:47–4:24

The Car Park

EXT. HOSPITAL CAR PARK — MOMENTS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe stands beside the Range Rover with rice still in her hair. She can't open the door because she gave the key back. She just stands there. Footsteps run up behind her. It's RITA, holding a packet of tissues.*

RITA *(breathless)* Madam. Madam, please, wait.

CHLOE *(not turning around)* Please. Don't look at me.

RITA *(handing her the tissues, her voice shaking)* I'm sorry, ma. I'm so sorry. I've worked for him for six years. I never knew—

CHLOE *(wiping her face)* Nobody knows. That's how he likes it.

> *Musa's old Corolla screeches into the car park. Musa jumps out, sweating, and sees her hair.*

MUSA *(his hand on his head)* Ah! Madam! Ah, God! *(beat, quietly)* Madam, I begged you. I begged you not to touch that car.

CHLOE *(a broken laugh)* It wasn't the car, Musa. *(beat)* It's never the car.

> *She gets into Musa's car. Rita watches it drive away, then looks up at Kunle's office window. He is standing there, watching too.*

SCENE 6 OF 53 · 4:24–5:10

"Why Is There Rice in Your Hair?"

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — BATHROOM / SITTING ROOM — AFTERNOON → NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe kneels over the bathtub, washing rice out of her hair and sobbing without a sound. Ada stands at the door.*

ADA Mummy, why is there rice in your hair?

CHLOE *(quickly wiping her face)* Mummy fell in the kitchen, baby.

ADA You didn't go to the kitchen. You went to Daddy's office.

> *Chloe has no answer.*

> *NIGHT. The front door opens. Kunle walks in, calm and smiling, and kisses Tobi's head. Chloe stands by the dining table with dinner served.*

KUNLE *(sitting)* The food you poured on yourself today was a waste. Do you know how much rice costs now?

CHLOE *(whispering)* I'm sorry.

KUNLE Listen to me carefully. You will never, ever come to my office in my car again. Do you understand? My staff saw you drive in like a market woman.

CHLOE Yes, darling.

KUNLE Good. *(tasting the soup)* Too much salt.

SCENE 7 OF 53 · 5:10–6:41

"I Will Tell Your Mother"

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — MASTER BEDROOM — NIGHT — TWO WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Sounds through the door: a crash, a cry, then silence. Inside, Chloe is on the floor beside the bed holding her arm, with her lip bleeding. Kunle stands over her, breathing hard.*

KUNLE I asked you a simple question. Where did the twenty thousand naira go?

CHLOE *(crying)* Ada's school trip. I told you. I showed you the receipt.

KUNLE You don't spend MY money without asking me!

> *Chloe pulls herself up against the bed and grabs her phone.*

CHLOE I'm calling your mother.

KUNLE *(freezing)* What?

CHLOE I'm calling Mama. I'll tell her everything you do to me. The rice. The slaps. Tonight. Everything.

> *She dials. "MAMA KUNLE" appears on the screen. Kunle snatches the phone and ends the call.*

KUNLE *(low, dangerous)* You call my mother, and I'll send you back to your father's house in Ibadan tonight. Without the children. You'll never see Ada and Tobi again.

> *Silence. Chloe stares at him. Then something changes in his face. He sinks to his knees in front of her.*

KUNLE *(suddenly soft, almost crying)* Chloe. Chloe, I'm sorry. It's the hospital. The board, the pressure. I don't know what came over me. *(He takes her hands.)* I'll never do it again. I swear on my father's grave. Please. Please, don't tell Mama.

CHLOE *(barely audible)* You said that last time.

KUNLE This time I mean it. *(He kisses her hands.)* I'm going to treat you like a queen. Watch me.

> *Her phone, on the floor, starts ringing. "MAMA KUNLE." The call she cut has rung back. Kunle and Chloe both freeze. He picks it up, presses it into her hand and whispers.*

KUNLE *(whispering)* Answer it. Smile.

CHLOE *(answering, voice trembling)* Good evening, Mama.

MAMA KUNLE (ON PHONE) Chloe? You called me just now. Is everything alright, my daughter?

> *Kunle kneels in front of her with his hands joined like a man praying, mouthing "please."*

CHLOE *(after a long, long pause)* It was a pocket dial, Mama. Everything is fine.

MAMA KUNLE (ON PHONE) *(a strange pause)* ...Are you sure, Chloe? You sound like you've been crying.

CHLOE *(closing her eyes)* I'm sure, Mama. Goodnight.

> *She hangs up. Kunle exhales and kisses her hands again and again.*

KUNLE Thank you. Thank you, my queen. You'll never regret it.

> *Chloe stares at the wall over his shoulder. She already does.*

SCENE 8 OF 53 · 6:41–7:21

The Good Husband

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — DINING ROOM — NEXT MORNING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The table is laid with fresh flowers, bread and egg. Kunle is pouring tea, which he has never done in nine years. Chloe enters, with her arm wrapped. The children stare.*

KUNLE Good morning, my queen. Sit. I made breakfast.

ADA *(whispering to Tobi)* Daddy can cook?

KUNLE *(laughing)* Daddy can do many things. *(He slides a paper to Chloe.)* Before I forget. My line has had no network for one week. MTN people are useless. So I bought a new SIM. Here's the number. Text me there for now.

CHLOE *(reading)* 0814 333 2197.

KUNLE Save it as "Darling New."

CHLOE *(quietly saving it)* Darling New.

> *He kisses her forehead and leaves for work. Chloe looks at the flowers, the bread and her wrapped arm.*

ADA Mummy, is Daddy sick?

CHLOE Why, baby?

ADA Because he's being nice.

SCENE 9 OF 53 · 7:21–8:04

The Line That Came Back

INT. KUNLE'S RANGE ROVER — NIGHT — PARKED OUTSIDE A LOUNGE IN WUSE 2

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Kunle sits in the driver's seat. NKEM (26), glamorous, is in the passenger seat, taking selfies. His phone buzzes with an SMS: "Dear customer, your line 0803 ••• ••12 has been restored. Thank you for choosing us."*

KUNLE *(smiling)* My old line is back.

NKEM So what happens to the new one? The one your wife texts every hour?

KUNLE *(pulling the new SIM out of his second phone)* I'll tell her to stop using it. Or maybe I won't. *(He laughs.)* A dead number is a very useful thing, Nkem. When I'm with you, I'm "unreachable."

NKEM You're wicked.

KUNLE I'm organised. *(He lowers the window and flicks the tiny SIM into the gutter.)* There. Wherever that number goes now, it's not my problem.

NKEM And if she texts it?

KUNLE Then she's talking to nobody. *(beat)* She's used to that.

SCENE 10 OF 53 · 8:04–9:08

Nobody Touches My Children

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — BEDROOM / STAIRCASE — FRIDAY, 7:10 AM — THREE WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe lies in bed shivering with a fever and a wet towel on her forehead. Kunle, dressed for work, stands at the door.*

KUNLE Chloe. It's ten past seven. Where is my breakfast?

CHLOE *(weak)* I'm sorry, darling. I have a fever. I couldn't stand up.

KUNLE You couldn't stand up, but you could lie down. *(sighing loudly)* Every day there's something. Listen. I'll eat lunch at the hospital. Bring it before one. And this time Musa drives you. If I see you behind the wheel of my car, God help you.

CHLOE Please, can I call Aunty Blessing to help with the children today? Just today?

KUNLE No. Nobody raises my children except their mother. *(He picks up his bag.)* Oh, and that new number, the 0814 one. It's dead. Use my old line from now on.

CHLOE *(coughing, eyes closed)* Okay.

ADA (O.S.) Mummy! Tobi is crying! He wants you!

KUNLE You heard me? The old line.

CHLOE *(already getting up for Tobi)* Yes, yes. I heard you.

> *He leaves. Chloe, dizzy, stumbles toward her son's cries. The instruction is already gone from her head.*

SCENE 11 OF 53 · 9:08–9:49

Ronke's Last Voice Note

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, SURULERE, LAGOS — THURSDAY NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A small, untidy flat. Unopened condolence cards are piled on a chair. A framed photo of RONKE (28), bald from chemotherapy and laughing anyway, sits on the table. EMMA WILLIAMS (35) sits on the floor in yesterday's clothes and presses play on her phone.*

RONKE (VOICE NOTE)
(weak, teasing) Emi. Emi, are you eating? Don't lie to me. I can hear you not eating. *(a small laugh)* Promise me something. When I'm gone, don't stop living just because I did. Promise.

> *The voice note ends. Emma plays it again. And again. Her phone buzzes. It's a text from MR. BAYO, her editor.*

BAYO
Your piece is dead. I gave the front page to Tayo. And don't ask about salary again this month.

> *Emma puts the phone face down. She stares at Ronke's photo for a long time.*

EMMA *(whispering)* I'm tired, Ronke. *(beat)* I'm so tired.

> *She picks the phone back up and types a message to Bisi. Her thumb trembles over SEND.*

EMMA
Bisi, thank you for everything. I'm sorry. Please don't be angry with me.

> *Send. She turns off the lamp. Darkness. Silence.*

SCENE 12 OF 53 · 9:49–10:37

"Jollof or Fried Rice?"

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — KITCHEN — FRIDAY, 2:14 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

Chloe is still feverish and sweating, with Tobi on her hip and Ada doing homework at the counter. She opens the fridge. One bowl of jollof rice. One bowl of fried rice. She freezes.

CHLOE *(whispering)* Jollof or fried? Jollof or fried? What did he say this morning?

She dials Kunle. It rings and rings. No answer.

CHLOE Please pick up. Please.

She hangs up, opens her messages and taps "Darling New."

CHLOE
Jollof rice or fried rice? Sorry, I forgot which one you wanted.

Send. 2:17 PM. She puts Tobi down and holds the edge of the counter. 2:19 PM. A reply.

UNKNOWN
Wrong receiver, but jollof rice with turkey sounds better 😂

Chloe stares at the screen.

CHLOE *(confused)* Wrong receiver?

ADA What is it, Mummy?

CHLOE I don't know. Maybe it's a fake number. *(beat)* Maybe Daddy's line has a scammer on it.

She switches to Kunle's old contact and types fast.

CHLOE
Jollof or fried rice?

A reply comes in seconds.

KUNLE
Fried. Musa is waiting outside. Don't be late.

Chloe exhales. She looks back at the stranger's message, "jollof rice with turkey sounds better 😂", and for one second, very small, she almost smiles.

ADA Mummy, you're smiling.

CHLOE *(the smile vanishing)* No, baby. Mummy has a fever. Pack your books.

SCENE 13 OF 53 · 10:37–11:18

The Drug Rep

INT. HOSPITAL — CORRIDOR OUTSIDE KUNLE'S OFFICE — 2:52 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe arrives with the cooler, pale with fever, with Musa a step behind her. Rita looks up from her desk, startled and nervous.*

RITA *(standing too quickly)* Madam! Good afternoon. You're early. Please, sit, I'll—

> *Kunle's office door opens. NKEM walks out, laughing and adjusting her dress, with a branded tote bag on her shoulder. She stops when she sees Chloe. They look at each other.*

NKEM *(smiling sweetly)* Good afternoon, ma.

CHLOE *(slowly)* Good afternoon. *(beat)* And you are?

RITA *(jumping in)* She's… a drug rep, ma. Pharmaceutical. She came about the new antibiotics.

NKEM *(tapping her bag)* Antibiotics. Yes.

> *Nkem walks past, her perfume trailing behind her. Chloe watches her go all the way to the lift, then looks at Rita, who can't meet her eyes.*

CHLOE *(quietly)* He didn't pick up my call at 2:14.

RITA *(barely audible)* He was… in a meeting, ma.

> *Kunle appears in the doorway with his tie slightly loose. He sees the cooler and smiles.*

KUNLE My queen! And with Musa this time. You see? You can learn. *(He takes the cooler.)* Fried rice?

CHLOE *(looking at the lift doors)* Fried rice.

KUNLE Good girl. Go home and rest. You look terrible.

> *He goes back in and closes the door. Chloe stands in the corridor. The perfume is still in the air.*

SCENE 14 OF 53 · 11:18–12:17

The Morning After

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, SURULERE, LAGOS — FRIDAY, 2:17 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Harsh afternoon light through the curtains. Emma lies on the floor beside the sofa, where the night left her. She is weak and dizzy, but alive. Her eyes flutter open, and she doesn't know where she is. Then her phone buzzes on the floor beside her face. She squints at the screen.*

CHLOE
Jollof rice or fried rice? Sorry, I forgot which one you wanted.

> *Emma stares at it. A stranger. A number she doesn't know. A question about rice. She laughs, a broken, cracked laugh that turns into sobbing. Then, with shaking fingers, she types.*

EMMA
Wrong receiver, but jollof rice with turkey sounds better 😂

> *Send. 2:19 PM. Pounding on the door.*

BISI (O.S.) EMMA! EMMA, OPEN THIS DOOR! I've been calling since midnight! EMMA!

> *Emma crawls to the door and unlocks it. BISI bursts in and falls to her knees, grabbing Emma's face.*

BISI *(sobbing)* What did you do? What did you DO? That message, Emma, that message!

EMMA *(barely audible)* I'm still here. *(beat)* I don't know why. But I'm still here.

BISI *(holding her tight)* We're going to the hospital. Now. And then we're getting you help. Real help. I don't care what you say.

> *Emma looks at the message on the screen through her tears.*

EMMA *(weakly)* Somebody in this world is worried about rice, Bisi.

BISI *(laughing and crying)* That's the new SIM you bought after the funeral. A recycled line. *(beat)* It carried somebody's wahala to you.

EMMA *(looking at the message)* Or it carried somebody's rice.

SCENE 15 OF 53 · 12:17–12:58

"Friday Stranger"

INT. CHLOE'S BEDROOM, ABUJA / INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — INTERCUT — THE NEXT FRIDAY, 2:19 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe folds laundry, fever gone. She scrolls back to the stranger's message. She remembers serving the fried rice last Friday. She hesitates, then types.*

CHLOE
For your information, fried rice was the correct answer.

EMMA
Ah. The rice woman returns. Correct according to who?

CHLOE
My husband.

EMMA
Then your husband simply has bad taste 😂

CHLOE
You don't know him.

EMMA
True. But anybody who rejects good jollof is already suspicious.

> *Chloe laughs out loud, a real laugh she hasn't heard from herself in years. Ada runs in.*

ADA Mummy! You're laughing!

CHLOE *(surprised at herself)* Yes. I suppose I am.

ADA Who made you laugh?

CHLOE *(looking at the phone)* A stranger.

> *Later, alone, Chloe edits the contact. She deletes "Darling New" and types: "FRIDAY STRANGER." Save.*

CHLOE
Same time next Friday?

EMMA
Only if you bring better rice opinions.

SCENE 16 OF 53 · 12:58–13:53

"Who Did You Use to Be?"

MONTAGE — LAGOS AND ABUJA — FRIDAYS OVER TWO MONTHS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

EMMA
Serious question. Is pineapple on pizza a crime?

CHLOE
My daughter eats it.

EMMA
She's young. Rehabilitation is possible.

Another Friday.

EMMA
How was your week, Rice Woman?

CHLOE
Don't call me that 😂

EMMA
Then tell me your name.

CHLOE
Chloe.

EMMA
Emma. Nice to meet you, Chloe of the disputed rice.

Another Friday, late at night. Chloe sits on the bedroom floor while Kunle snores.

CHLOE
Emma, do you think people can forget who they used to be?

EMMA
Yes. But I don't think the old person disappears completely.

CHLOE
How do you find her again?

EMMA

Start with one thing that used to make you happy.

> *Chloe looks up at the top shelf of the wardrobe. She stands on a stool and pulls down a dusty folder: "CHLOE ADEYEMI — INTERIOR DESIGN PORTFOLIO." She opens it. Sketches of beautiful rooms. Colour swatches. Her own handwriting.*

CHLOE

I think I remember something.

EMMA

Then hold on to it. Don't let anybody put it back on that shelf.

SCENE 17 OF 53 · 13:53–14:43

The Voice

INT. CHLOE'S CAR (PARKED IN THE GARAGE), ABUJA / INT. EMMA'S BALCONY, LAGOS — FRIDAY, 9:40 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe sits in the back seat of the family Lexus in the dark garage. It's the only place in the house without ears.*

CHLOE
Can I call you? Just once. I want to know what you sound like.

EMMA
Only if you promise not to judge my Lagos accent.

> *Chloe's thumb hovers. Then she presses call. It rings once.*

EMMA *(warm, a little nervous)* Hello? Rice Woman?

CHLOE *(a shaky laugh)* You sound exactly like your texts.

EMMA Is that good or bad?

CHLOE *(quietly)* It's good. *(beat)* You sound like somebody who isn't angry.

EMMA *(softly)* Chloe… why are you whispering?

CHLOE Because I'm in the garage. *(beat)* It's the only room in my house where nobody listens.

> *Silence in Lagos. Then headlights sweep across the garage wall. The gate is opening. Kunle's car.*

CHLOE *(panicking)* He's home. I have to go.

EMMA Chloe—

> *Click. Chloe wipes her face, checks herself in the mirror, practises a smile and steps out of the car just as Kunle's headlights hit her.*

KUNLE *(from his window)* What are you doing in the garage at this hour?

CHLOE *(smiling)* Looking for Tobi's toy, darling.

ACT TWO

The Husband Reads the Phone

SCENE 18 OF 53 · 14:43–16:23

"My Wife Would Forget Her Own Head"

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — DINING ROOM — NIGHT — SIX MONTHS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

A dinner party. Kunle hosts four business GUESTS. Chloe has cooked everything and stands serving.

GUEST Kunle, this egusi is a masterpiece. Your wife should open a restaurant!

KUNLE *(laughing)* Please, don't encourage her. If I leave Chloe alone, she'll forget her own head. I have to supervise everything in this house. Even the salt.

The guests laugh. Chloe smiles along.

GUEST And she used to be a designer, abi? I remember the wedding brochure.

CHLOE Yes, I trained in interior design. I've been thinking of taking small—

KUNLE *(cutting in smoothly)* She's been thinking of making my life difficult. *(laughter)* Chloe, darling, bring the dessert.

LATER. The guests are gone. Kunle loosens his tie.

KUNLE "Small projects"? You announced that in front of MY guests?

CHLOE I was only answering the question.

KUNLE You always have an explanation. *(He leaves.)*

Chloe sits on the edge of the bed in the dark and opens FRIDAY STRANGER.

CHLOE
Emma, can somebody make you feel useless without ever saying the word "useless"?

EMMA
Yes. How someone treats you matters as much as the words they use.

CHLOE
And what if everybody thinks he's wonderful?

EMMA
They're judging the man they see at dinner. You're living with the man you know at night.

A long pause. Chloe's thumb shakes.

CHLOE

I think I'm afraid of my husband.

> *In Lagos, Emma puts down her plate.*

EMMA

Chloe. Are you and the children safe right now?

CHLOE

Yes. He's asleep.

EMMA

Then you don't have to decide anything tonight. But you shouldn't have to live afraid. Is there one person in Abuja you trust?

CHLOE

I used to have friends.

EMMA

Maybe one of them is still waiting to hear from you.

SCENE 19 OF 53 · 16:23–17:13

Halima

INT. CAFÉ, WUSE 2, ABUJA — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe sits across from HALIMA, her old university friend, with sunglasses on indoors.*

HALIMA Three years, Chloe. Three years, and suddenly you call me at 7 a.m. and say "please, can we see"? *(beat)* Take off the glasses.

> *Chloe slowly removes them. There's a faded bruise on her cheekbone. Halima goes quiet.*

HALIMA *(softly)* How long?

CHLOE Since Tobi was born. *(beat)* Sometimes I don't even know if it's bad enough to complain about.

HALIMA You don't have to prove your pain to me. *(She takes Chloe's hand.)* Why didn't you tell me?

CHLOE Because I thought you'd ask me why I stayed.

HALIMA I'm not asking why you stayed. I'm asking how I can help you. *(beat)* Who told you to call me?

CHLOE *(a small smile)* A stranger who answered a wrong number.

SCENE 20 OF 53 · 17:13–18:56

The Byline

INT. THE LAGOS HERALD — NEWSROOM, IKEJA — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A crowded, noisy newsroom with old computers and a broken air conditioner. Emma, thinner and still fragile but working, stands at the desk of MR. BAYO ADEKOLA, the editor. He holds her printed article.*

EMMA Sir, it's the hospital story. Three weeks of interviews. The patients' families are ready to go on record.

BAYO *(tossing it into the bin)* Nobody wants to read sad stories about poor people, Emma. *(beat)* Tayo will rewrite it. His name goes on it.

EMMA *(steady)* Sir, that's my story. And it's been four months since we were paid.

BAYO *(loud, so the whole newsroom hears)* Ten years in this office, and you're still begging for your own name on your own story? If you don't like it, the gate is open.

> *Silence in the newsroom. Emma picks her article out of the bin, smooths it flat and walks back to her desk. Bisi squeezes her hand as she passes. At her desk, Emma opens the contact she saved weeks ago: "RICE WOMAN."*

EMMA
Bad day. My editor binned my story in front of everybody. Ten years. I'm starting to think I'm just not good enough.

> *In Abuja, Chloe reads it at the kitchen counter.*

CHLOE
Then write the next one. And the next one. Let them get tired before you do.

EMMA
That's my kind of advice. Where did you steal it?

CHLOE
From a stranger who told me not to let anybody put my portfolio back on the shelf. (beat) Don't let them put you in the bin, Emma.

> *Emma looks at the crumpled article for a long time. Then, slowly, she types something she has never told anyone.*

EMMA

Can I tell you something? Some nights I don't want to wake up, Chloe. Since my sister died.

In Abuja, Chloe goes completely still. She puts down the spoon.

CHLOE

Emma. Thank you for telling me. Are you safe right now?

EMMA

Yes. I'm at work. Bisi is here.

CHLOE

Then promise me something. Talk to a doctor. This week. (beat) You told me to call Halima. Now I'm telling you to see somebody.

EMMA

(after a long pause) Okay. I promise.

Emma opens a new document and starts typing the next story.

SCENE 21 OF 53 · 18:56–20:18

Dr. Ifeoma

INT. COUNSELLING ROOM, LAGOS — DAY — SAME WEEK

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A quiet room with plants and a box of tissues. DR. IFEOMA, a calm woman in her fifties, sits across from Emma. Bisi waits outside.*

DR. IFEOMA Bisi drove you here. But you're the one who walked in. That matters. *(beat)* Tell me about that Thursday night.

EMMA *(looking at her hands)* My sister fought cancer for two years. She fought for every single day. And I'm the one who gave up. *(beat)* What kind of sister does that?

DR. IFEOMA A sister who's been carrying grief alone for three months, with no sleep and no salary. *(gently)* Grief like that can make the dark feel like the only room in the house. It isn't.

EMMA *(a small, surprised laugh)* That's funny. My friend in Abuja says her garage is the only room in her house where nobody listens.

DR. IFEOMA Your friend in Abuja?

EMMA A stranger. She texted me by mistake the afternoon I woke up. About rice. *(beat)* She's the one who told me to come here. She said, "You told me to call Halima. I'm telling you to see somebody."

DR. IFEOMA *(smiling)* Then let's make sure that stranger gets to keep texting you for a very long time. *(beat)* Same time next week, Emma?

EMMA *(after a long pause)* Same time next week.

SCENE 22 OF 53 · 20:18–21:01

"Who Gave You Permission?"

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — DINING ROOM — NIGHT — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Design sketches cover the dining table. Chloe has a small paid job: a client's living room. Kunle walks in and picks up a sketch.*

KUNLE What is this?

CHLOE A proposal. Halima's cousin is paying me to redesign her living room.

KUNLE Paying you?

CHLOE Two hundred thousand naira.

KUNLE *(laughing coldly)* You think because somebody gave you small money, you can do whatever you want? *(He crumples the sketch.)* Who gave you permission?

CHLOE *(standing)* I didn't know I needed permission to use my own hands.

> *Silence. She has never answered back before. Kunle stares at her as if a stranger has walked into his house.*

KUNLE *(quietly)* Who is putting this nonsense in your head?

CHLOE Nobody. *(beat)* Me.

> *He grabs her arm hard. She cries out. The children's door creaks open. Ada is watching.*

KUNLE *(letting go, smiling at Ada)* Go back to bed, princess. *(to Chloe, whispering)* We'll finish this when I come back tomorrow.

> *He walks out. Chloe holds her arm and shakes.*

SCENE 23 OF 53 · 21:01–21:26

She Is Laughing

EXT/INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — FRONT DOOR / SITTING ROOM — NEXT EVENING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Kunle comes home early, expecting to find a broken woman. His key is in the lock when he hears something through the door. Laughter. Chloe's laughter, loud and free.*

CHLOE *(on the phone, laughing)* No! Emma, you didn't! You told your boss THAT?
O.S.

> *Kunle slowly pushes the door open. Chloe sits on the sofa with the phone at her ear and Tobi asleep on her lap. She sees him, and her laughter stops.*

CHLOE *(into the phone)* I'll call you back. *(She hangs up.)*

KUNLE *(calmly, putting his bag down)* Who was that?

CHLOE Halima.

KUNLE Halima. *(He holds out his hand.)* Open your phone.

CHLOE Kunle—

KUNLE Open. It.

> *Chloe unlocks it and gives it to him. Her heart is pounding. He scrolls. The call log shows "FRIDAY STRANGER — 47 min." He looks at the screen for a long time. Then he hands the phone back with a pleasant smile.*

KUNLE Tell Halima I said hello.

> *He goes upstairs whistling. Chloe sits frozen. That smile frightens her more than any slap.*

SCENE 24 OF 53 · 21:26–22:09

3:07 A.M.

INT. MASTER BEDROOM — 3:07 AM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Darkness. Chloe sleeps on her side, her phone on the bedside table. Kunle sits up silently. He lifts her limp hand and presses her thumb onto the phone. It unlocks.*

> *He opens the chat with FRIDAY STRANGER. Months of messages. He reads them in a whisper.*

KUNLE *(reading)* "You're living with the man you know at night." *(beat)* "Don't let anybody put it back on that shelf." *(His jaw tightens.)* "Emma." *(He sneers.)* Emmanuel. A man. Of course. A man.

> *He types slowly, with a terrible calm.*

KUNLE, TYPING AS CHLOE

Stop texting me. You are not my friend. You are a useless man with no home of your own, poking your nose into my marriage. My husband is a good man. I'm tired of your poison. Don't ever contact me again. Lose my number.

> *Send. Then he deletes the entire chat and blocks the number. He puts the phone back exactly where it was and lies down. In the dark, his eyes stay open.*

KUNLE *(whispering)* Goodnight, Emmanuel.

SCENE 25 OF 53 · 22:09–22:59

"Are We Fighting?"

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — 6:40 AM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Emma wakes up and reaches for her phone. She reads the message once, then sits up and reads it again.*

EMMA *(whispering)* "A useless man"?

> *She calls Bisi.*

BISI *(sleepy)* Who died?
ON PHONE

EMMA Bisi. Chloe sent me something at three in the morning. "You are not my friend. Lose my number."

BISI *(waking up)* Ah. What did you do?
ON PHONE

EMMA Nothing! We were laughing yesterday. Forty-seven minutes! *(beat)* And she called me a MAN. "A useless man with no home of your own." Bisi, she knows I'm a woman. We've talked on the phone.

BISI *(slowly)* So why would she call you a man?
ON PHONE

> *Emma goes very still.*

EMMA Unless she didn't write it.

> *She types fast.*

EMMA
Chloe? Are we fighting? What did I do? Please talk to me.

> *One grey tick. Not delivered. She calls. A recorded voice says: "The number you are calling is not available at the moment."*

EMMA *(barely audible)* She blocked me.

SCENE 26 OF 53 · 22:59–24:21

"Why Do You Even Care?"

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — NIGHT — SAME DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Emma sits on the floor against her sofa holding the framed photo of Ronke. Bisi has come over with food that nobody is eating.*

BISI Emma, I have to ask. Why do you care this much? You've never even seen this woman's face. And she's blocked you.

EMMA *(quietly)* Because you don't know what her first text was, Bisi.

BISI "Jollof or fried rice." Everybody in Lagos knows that story.

EMMA *(shaking her head)* You know the joke. You don't know the time. *(beat)* It came at 2:17 the afternoon after that Thursday. I'd just opened my eyes on that floor. *(She points.)* Right there. I didn't want to be alive. And my phone buzzed, and a stranger was asking me about rice like the world still had ordinary problems in it.

> *Bisi slowly puts down her plate.*

EMMA I laughed, Bisi. For the first time since Ronke's funeral. *(Her voice breaks.)* She doesn't even know she saved my life. She thinks I saved hers.

BISI *(her eyes wet)* Then tell her.

EMMA I can't. She's blocked me. Somebody called me "a useless man" from her phone. *(She looks at the photo.)* Ronke never let anybody shut a door on me. *(beat)* I won't let anybody shut this one.

BISI *(sliding Emma's office phone across the floor)* Then don't knock on the same door. Use another number.

SCENE 27 OF 53 · 24:21–25:08

The Month of Silence

MONTAGE — ABUJA AND LAGOS — FOUR FRIDAYS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *FRIDAY ONE, 2:19 PM. Chloe opens her phone. The chat with Friday Stranger is gone, and so is the contact.*

CHLOE *(scrolling, panicking)* Where is it? Where did it go?

> *She tries to call the number from memory. "This number cannot receive calls from you."*

CHLOE *(whispering)* She blocked me. *(beat)* She got tired of me. Everybody gets tired of me.

> *FRIDAY TWO. Lagos. Emma sits at her desk staring at the phone, then puts it face down.*

BISI Still nothing?

EMMA *(quietly)* Maybe she was right. Maybe I'm just a stranger poking my nose in.

> *FRIDAY THREE. Abuja dinner table. Chloe eats in silence with her eyes down. Kunle watches her and smiles.*

KUNLE You've been very quiet lately, darling.

CHLOE I'm just tired.

KUNLE *(pleased)* I like it. *(beat)* This is the woman I married.

> *FRIDAY FOUR. Kunle on the phone in his office, laughing with Nkem.*

KUNLE She's back to normal. No more laughing on the phone. No more "proposals." *(He leans back.)* I told you, Nkem. Every candle can be dimmed. You just have to find the right wind.

SCENE 28 OF 53 · 25:08–26:02

The Archive

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — CHILDREN'S ROOM / KITCHEN — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

LAGOS, THE NIGHT BEFORE. Emma sits on her bed, takes out her old SIM and puts in her office line.

EMMA *(to herself)* If she hates me, she hates me. But I won't be ghosted by a three-in-the-morning message.

EMMA

Chloe, it's Emma, from my office line. Whatever I did, I'm sorry. But that message didn't sound like you. You know I'm a woman. If you're safe, you don't have to reply. I just need you to know I'm still here.

ABUJA, 3 A.M. Kunle, half asleep, sees Chloe's phone light up. A new number. He reads the preview. He archives the chat, blocks the number and goes back to sleep.

THE NEXT DAY. Ada sits on her bed playing a game on Mummy's phone. She taps the wrong button and a hidden folder opens: "ARCHIVED (1)."

ADA Mummy! Who is "Emma"? There's a secret message in your phone!

Chloe drops the plate she's washing. It shatters. She runs and grabs the phone. She reads Emma's message, then reads it again. Her face crumbles.

CHLOE *(whispering)* "That message didn't sound like you." *(beat)* What message?

She scrolls with shaking hands. Then she understands. The deleted chat. The block. Three o'clock in the morning. Her husband's pleasant smile.

CHLOE *(her hand over her mouth)* Kunle.

ADA Mummy, are you crying because of the secret message?

CHLOE *(kneeling and hugging her tight)* No, baby. I'm crying because somebody didn't give up on Mummy.

SCENE 29 OF 53 · 26:02–27:10

"It Was My Husband"

INT. HALIMA'S CAR — PARKED OUTSIDE A SUPERMARKET, ABUJA — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Chloe sits in Halima's car on Halima's phone, crying. Halima sits beside her and holds her hand.*

EMMA (ON PHONE) Hello? Who is this?

CHLOE *(barely able to speak)* Emma. It's me.

> *Silence on the line.*

EMMA (ON PHONE) *(quietly)* Chloe.

CHLOE I never sent that message. I swear to God, I never sent it. He opened my phone while I was asleep. He used my finger. He deleted everything and blocked you. *(sobbing)* I thought you left me. For a whole month, I thought you got tired of me.

EMMA (ON PHONE) *(her voice breaking)* And I thought you got tired of me.

CHLOE I'm so sorry.

EMMA (ON PHONE) Stop. Don't you dare apologise for something HE did. *(beat)* Chloe, listen to me. He called me a man. He thinks I'm a man.

CHLOE *(stunned)* What?

EMMA (ON PHONE) "A useless man with no home of your own." That's what he wrote. He thinks you've been talking to a boyfriend for a year. *(beat)* That's why he hasn't come for you yet. He's looking for a man.

> *Chloe and Halima look at each other in horror.*

HALIMA *(whispering)* Chloe, that man is dangerous.

SCENE 30 OF 53 · 27:10–28:19

"Divorce Him"

INT. CHLOE'S BATHROOM, ABUJA / INT. EMMA'S CAR, LAGOS — NIGHT — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

Chloe sits on the bathroom floor with the shower running to drown out her voice, on a secret second phone Halima gave her. Emma is parked in her car in Lagos traffic.

EMMA I've been quiet for a year. I've been careful. I've said "one day at a time." But Chloe, I'm going to say it plainly once, and then you can be angry with me.

CHLOE Say it.

EMMA Divorce him.

A long silence. Only the shower running.

CHLOE *(whispering)* Divorce? Emma, this is Abuja. He's Dr. Kunle Adeyemi. He knows commissioners. Judges come to his hospital. He told me if I leave, I'll never see my children again.

EMMA That's what men like him say so you'll never check if it's true. *(beat)* Talk to a lawyer. Just talk. Talking isn't leaving. But please, don't stay because you're scared of the door.

CHLOE *(crying softly)* And if he finds out?

EMMA Then he finds out that his wife has people now.

A bang on the bathroom door. Chloe freezes.

KUNLE (O.S.) Chloe! Who are you talking to in there?

Chloe hides the phone inside a towel. Emma hears it and holds her breath in Lagos.

CHLOE *(steadying her voice)* Myself. I'm praying.

KUNLE (O.S.) *(after a pause)* Pray faster. I want to use the bathroom.

SCENE 31 OF 53 · 28:19–29:39

"Who Is Emmanuel?"

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — SITTING ROOM — NIGHT — DAYS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Kunle sits on the sofa holding the second phone. He found it in the towel cupboard. Chloe stands frozen at the foot of the stairs.*

KUNLE *(very calm)* A second phone. In my house. *(He holds it up.)* Who bought it?

CHLOE Kunle, please—

KUNLE WHO IS EMMANUEL?

CHLOE *(confused, terrified)* Who?

KUNLE Don't play with me! "Emma"! The man you've been whispering to for a year! The man who told you to start "designing"! I read everything, Chloe. Everything!

> *He dials the only number in the second phone and puts it on speaker. It rings. Chloe covers her mouth.*

EMMA (ON PHONE) Chloe? Are you okay?

KUNLE *(snarling into the phone)* This is her HUSBAND. Listen to me, Emmanuel. You think you can break my home from Lagos? I'm going to find you. I'm going to come to Lagos, and I'm going to deal with you like the small boy you are.

> *A pause on the line. Then a calm female voice.*

EMMA (ON PHONE) My name is Emma Williams. I'm a woman, Dr. Adeyemi. You've been jealous of the wrong person for a year. *(beat)* And you're the man who pours rice on his wife and beats her when nobody's looking.

> *Kunle's face changes completely. He looks at Chloe.*

KUNLE *(to the phone, shaken, then furious)* You don't know anything about my home.

EMMA (ON PHONE) I know enough. You said you're coming to Lagos? Come. The Lagos Herald, Allen Avenue, Ikeja, fourth floor. I'll be waiting for you.

> *Click. Kunle slowly lowers the phone. The house is completely silent.*

KUNLE *(quietly, to Chloe)* You told a stranger about the rice.

SCENE 32 OF 53 · 29:39–30:59

The Ticket

INT. HOSPITAL — RITA'S DESK / INT. HALIMA'S CAR — INTERCUT — NEXT MORNING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Rita sits at her desk, glancing at Kunle's closed door. She takes out her personal phone and dials with shaking fingers. In Halima's car, Chloe answers on the secret phone.*

CHLOE Hello?

RITA *(whispering)* Madam, it's Rita. From the hospital. Please don't say my name out loud.

CHLOE *(alarmed)* Rita? What's wrong?

RITA He told me to cancel all his appointments for tomorrow. He's bought a ticket. Abuja to Lagos, 7 a.m. *(beat)* Madam, he asked me to search the internet for "The Lagos Herald, Ikeja." He printed the address.

> *Chloe's hand flies to her mouth.*

RITA And madam… he was holding his golf club when he said it. I don't know what he's going to do.

CHLOE *(barely breathing)* Why are you telling me this, Rita?

RITA *(after a pause)* Because I cleaned that rice off the carpet, madam. And I've never forgiven myself for staying quiet.

> *She hangs up. Chloe immediately dials Emma.*

CHLOE Emma, he's coming. Tomorrow morning. He has your address. Please, please don't be there. Stay home. Go to Bisi's. Anywhere.

EMMA *(a long silence)* Chloe. I'm the one who told him to come.
ON PHONE

CHLOE Emma, you don't know him!

EMMA No. But I know you. *(beat)* For ten months, you've been scared alone. Tomorrow, he finds out what it feels like when somebody isn't scared of him.
ON PHONE

SCENE 33 OF 53 · 30:59–32:18

Fourth Floor

INT. THE LAGOS HERALD, IKEJA — NEWSROOM RECEPTION — DAY — TWO DAYS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A crowded newsroom, with reporters, ringing phones and cameras everywhere. Kunle storms in, still in his white coat from the flight, and slams his hand on the reception desk.*

KUNLE Emma Williams. NOW.

SECURITY GUARD Sir, please calm down—

> *Emma walks out of the lift. She is calm, but her hands are folded tight to stop them shaking. Behind her, Bisi holds up her phone, already recording.*

EMMA You came.

KUNLE *(looking her up and down)* So you're the "friend." You're the one filling my wife's head with rubbish.

EMMA I'm the one she texted by mistake. And I'm the one she told the truth to. *(beat)* I'm also a journalist, Doctor. Ten years. Say what you came to say, carefully.

KUNLE *(stepping closer)* Stay away from my family. You don't know her. You've never even seen her face.

EMMA No, I haven't. *(beat)* But I've heard her apologise four times in one message for things she didn't do. I've heard her laugh like it's illegal. And I know about the rice.

KUNLE *(losing control, loud enough for the whole office)* She is MY wife! I'll discipline her the way I like! In my house, I am the law!

> *Silence. Fifty staff are watching. Emma turns slightly to Bisi's phone.*

EMMA *(very quietly)* Can you say that again, slowly, Doctor? For the camera.

> *Kunle sees the phone and lunges for it. The guard and two staff grab him.*

SECURITY GUARD Oga! Not here! Out! OUT!

> *They drag him to the door. He shouts over his shoulder.*

KUNLE You'll regret this! Both of you will regret this!

> *The doors close. The office is silent. Emma's knees give way, and Bisi catches her.*

EMMA *(shaking)* Bisi, I've just faced her husband. *(beat)* And I've never even seen her face.

BISI *(holding up the phone)* We have everything. Every word.

SCENE 34 OF 53 · 32:18–33:20

The Night He Came Back

INT. ADEYEMI MANSION — NIGHT — SAME DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *11:48 p.m. Headlights sweep the window. Chloe stands at the curtain. Ada is in the doorway holding Tobi's hand.*

ADA *(whispering)* Mummy, is Daddy angry?

CHLOE *(calm, too calm)* Ada, listen to me. Take Tobi into Mummy's room. Lock the door. Don't open it for anybody but me. Do you understand?

ADA Yes, Mummy.

> *The front door slams. Kunle's voice fills the house.*

KUNLE CHLOE! You sent a woman to disgrace me in front of the whole of Lagos?!

> *Chloe runs upstairs into the bedroom and locks it behind her. Her hands are shaking so badly she can barely press the buttons on the secret phone.*

CHLOE *(whispering)* Halima. It's tonight. Come now. Please.

HALIMA ON PHONE I'm already in the car. Garba is with me. Ten minutes. Don't open that door.

> *BANG. BANG. Kunle pounds on the bedroom door.*

KUNLE Open this door! It's MY door! In MY house!

> *Tobi starts crying. Ada covers his mouth gently and holds him. Chloe pulls out a suitcase she packed weeks ago and hid under the bed.*

KUNLE Chloe! If you make me break this door—

> *Headlights. A car horn blasts at the gate. Then another voice, a man's, deep and loud.*

GARBA O.S. DR. ADEYEMI! It's Garba! Halima's husband! I've called the police at Asokoro station. They're on their way.

> *The banging stops. Silence.*

CHLOE *(opening the door, suitcase in one hand and Tobi in the other)* Move, Kunle.

KUNLE *(blocking the corridor, quietly)* If you walk out of that gate tonight, you'll never come back.

CHLOE *(looking straight past him)* I'm not coming back.

> *She walks past him with Ada holding her dress. He doesn't touch her. Every neighbour's light is now on. The gate closes behind them.*

SCENE 35 OF 53 · 33:20–34:10

Three Fridays

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS / INT. HALIMA'S GUEST ROOM, ABUJA — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

EMMA
Morning, Abuja. What's the rice controversy today?

No reply. The next Friday.

EMMA
Chloe, after what happened in my office, I'm scared. Just one word. Please.

No reply. The third Friday. Emma paces her living room and calls Bisi.

EMMA It's been three weeks, Bisi. What if he… what if I made it worse? What if I got her hurt by—

Her phone buzzes. A new number.

CHLOE
It's me. New number. I'm still here.

Emma sits down on the floor.

CHLOE
The children and I are safe. We left that night. We're at Halima's.

EMMA
(typing through tears) Thank God. Thank God. How are you holding up?

CHLOE
Scared. Confused. I cried the whole night. (beat) But Emma, I slept. I slept without listening for his car.

SCENE 36 OF 53 · 34:10–35:10

Mama Kunle

INT. HALIMA'S HOUSE, ABUJA — SITTING ROOM — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

A knock. Halima opens the door and steps back. MAMA KUNLE (65), elegant and stern, walks in. Chloe stands up, terrified, and pulls Ada behind her.

CHLOE Mama. *(beat)* Please. If he sent you to bring me back—

MAMA KUNLE Sit down, Chloe.

Chloe sits. Mama Kunle sits opposite her and looks at her for a long time.

MAMA KUNLE He called me last night. He said you've run away with a man from Lagos. *(beat)* Then he said the man was a woman. *(beat)* Then he cried. Then he shouted. *(She removes her glasses.)* I know that sound, Chloe. I lived with it for thirty-one years. His father.

Chloe's eyes fill with tears.

MAMA KUNLE I stayed because everybody told me to stay. Pastor. My mother. My in-laws. *(beat)* And I raised a boy in that house who learned that a woman is something you own.

She leans forward and takes Chloe's hands.

MAMA KUNLE Don't you dare go back. *(beat)* And if you need somebody to stand in that court and tell them what I know, I'm his mother. I'll stand.

SCENE 37 OF 53 · 35:10–36:04

"Threats Are Not Court Orders"

INT. BARRISTER ZAINAB BELLO'S CHAMBERS, ABUJA — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *BARRISTER ZAINAB BELLO, sharp and calm, flips through a thick file. Chloe sits across from her.*

ZAINAB He's filed a response. He says you abandoned the matrimonial home, you're mentally unstable, and you've been "manipulated by a stranger on the phone." He wants full custody.

CHLOE *(trembling)* He said he'd make sure I never see the children again.

ZAINAB Threats are not court orders, Chloe. *(She taps the file.)* Now. What do we have?

CHLOE Emma's video from Lagos. "I'll discipline her the way I like." Hospital records from when he hurt my arm. Halima. *(beat)* And his mother.

ZAINAB *(looking up sharply)* His own mother?

CHLOE His own mother.

ZAINAB *(a slow smile)* He knows important people, Chloe. Good. Let's see how important they feel when his mother walks into that courtroom.

SCENE 38 OF 53 · 36:04–38:45

The Witness

INT. FEDERAL HIGH COURT, ABUJA — COURTROOM — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A packed courtroom. Kunle sits with his lawyer, MR. OKORO, in an expensive agbada, calm and confident. Chloe sits with Zainab. Halima and Mama Kunle are in the gallery.*

MR. OKORO My Lord, Dr. Adeyemi is one of the most respected physicians in Abuja. To prove his gentle character, we call a witness who has worked beside him for eight years. His secretary, Miss Rita Okafor.

> *Rita walks to the witness box nervously. Kunle smiles at her and gives her a small nod.*

MR. OKORO Miss Okafor, in eight years, have you ever seen Dr. Adeyemi be violent toward anyone?

> *Rita looks at Kunle, then at Chloe. A long pause.*

RITA *(quietly)* Yes.

> *Gasps around the courtroom. Kunle's smile freezes.*

MR. OKORO *(confused)* I… I'm sorry?

RITA *(her voice getting stronger)* Two years ago, Mrs. Adeyemi brought his lunch to the office. She drove his car because the driver was buying fuel. He poured the hot rice on her head. In front of me. Then he told me to call the cleaners. *(beat)* I cleaned that rice off the carpet myself, My Lord. I've been ashamed every day since.

KUNLE *(standing)* Rita! Are you mad?

JUDGE Sit DOWN, Dr. Adeyemi.

ZAINAB *(rising calmly)* My Lord, the respondent says he's a gentle man. I'd like the court to see how gentle. Exhibit C. Recorded in Lagos.

> *The video plays on the courtroom screen. Kunle is shouting in the Lagos office: "She is MY wife! I'll discipline her the way I like! In my house, I am the law!"*

> *Silence. Then Mama Kunle stands up in the gallery.*

MAMA KUNLE My Lord, I'm his mother. *(Her voice shakes but doesn't break.)* I'd like to speak.

JUDGE *(after a pause)* Come forward, madam.

> *Mama Kunle walks slowly to the witness box. Kunle stands up.*

KUNLE Mama, what are you doing? Mama, sit down!

MAMA KUNLE *(not looking at him)* I sat down for thirty-one years, Kunle. *(to the judge)* My Lord, my husband beat me in front of this boy until he was fifteen. And every time, I told him, "Daddy is just tired." *(beat)* I taught my son that a man's anger is a woman's job to manage. *(She finally looks at Kunle.)* I was wrong. And my daughter-in-law has paid for my lesson.

> *Kunle sits down slowly, like a man whose legs have stopped working.*

MAMA KUNLE Give those children to their mother, My Lord. So that my granddaughter never has to learn what I learned.

> *LATER. Chloe stands in the witness box. Mr. Okoro circles her like a hawk.*

MR. OKORO Mrs. Adeyemi, isn't it true that for an entire year you were secretly texting a stranger? A person you have never even met?

CHLOE Yes.

MR. OKORO A stranger who told you to "divorce" your husband. Who told you to leave a beautiful home, a respected man, a comfortable life. *(to the judge)* My Lord, this woman was manipulated by a voice on a phone.

CHLOE *(steady)* May I answer, My Lord?

JUDGE Go on.

CHLOE For nine years, I lived with a man everyone could see. And I disappeared. *(beat)* For one year, I talked to a woman nobody could see. And I came back. *(She looks at Kunle.)* So tell me, sir. Which of them was manipulating me?

> *The courtroom is silent. Mr. Okoro opens his mouth, then closes it.*

MR. OKORO *(quietly)* No further questions, My Lord.

SCENE 39 OF 53 · 38:45–39:45

"Let's Go Home"

INT. COURTROOM → EXT. COURT STEPS — DAY — WEEKS LATER

Images Voice Edited

JUDGE Having considered all the evidence and the welfare of the children, this court dissolves the marriage. Primary custody of Ada and Tobi is granted to the petitioner, Mrs. Chloe Adeyemi, with supervised access for the father.

Chloe sits very still. Zainab touches her arm.

ZAINAB Chloe?

CHLOE *(whispering)* It's over?

ZAINAB This part is over. The next part is yours.

Kunle walks past their table. He stops and leans down.

KUNLE *(low)* You think this is finished?

CHLOE *(without looking up)* No, Kunle. I think it's started.

OUTSIDE. Bright Abuja sun. Ada and Tobi break away from Halima and run into Chloe's arms.

ADA Mummy, can we go home now?

CHLOE *(holding them both)* Yes, my darlings. Let's go home. Our own home.

THAT NIGHT.

CHLOE
We have a home. The children are with me. We did it.

EMMA
YOU did it, Chloe. You, Halima, Zainab, his mother, Rita. Everybody who stood up. (beat) I'm so proud of you, I'm crying in a Lagos traffic jam.

SCENE 40 OF 53 · 39:45–40:40

"Why Did You Pour Rice on Mummy?"

INT. HALIMA'S HOUSE — SITTING ROOM — SUPERVISED VISIT — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Kunle sits on Halima's sofa with expensive gifts piled next to him: a tablet, a toy car, a designer bag for Ada. Halima watches from the dining table. Tobi plays with the toy car. Ada stands in front of her father with her arms folded and doesn't touch her gift.*

KUNLE *(smiling)* Princess. Don't you like the bag? It's from Dubai.

ADA Daddy, can I ask you a question?

KUNLE Anything, my princess.

ADA Why did you pour rice on Mummy?

> *Silence. Halima puts down her cup. Kunle's smile freezes.*

KUNLE *(carefully)* Who told you that? Did your mother tell you that?

ADA Nobody told me. I saw the rice in her hair. You thought I was too small. *(beat)* I was seven. I'm nine now.

KUNLE Ada, sometimes grown-ups—

ADA You always said a man who can't be gentle with the weak has no business wearing a white coat. I heard you practise it in the mirror. *(Her voice shakes.)* So why weren't you gentle with Mummy?

> *Kunle opens his mouth. Nothing comes out. For the first time in the film, he has no answer at all. Ada picks up Tobi's hand.*

ADA Come, Tobi. Daddy's visit is finished.

> *She walks out. Kunle sits alone among his expensive gifts.*

SCENE 41 OF 53 · 40:40–41:39

The White Coat

INT. ADEYEMI SPECIALIST HOSPITAL — BOARDROOM — DAY — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The same boardroom from Scene 3. Twelve board members sit in silence. Kunle stands at the head of the table, confident, in his white coat.*

KUNLE Gentlemen, ladies. A private family matter has been blown out of proportion by—

BOARD CHAIRMAN Sit down, Kunle.

> *Kunle hesitates, then sits.*

BOARD CHAIRMAN We've seen the court judgment. We've seen the video from Lagos. *(He slides a printed page across the table.)* And we've read the minutes of your own speech in this room. *(reading)* "A man who cannot be gentle with the weak has no business wearing a white coat." *(He looks up.)* Your words, Kunle.

KUNLE *(stiff)* That was about patients.

BOARD CHAIRMAN Your wife was a patient in this hospital. *(beat)* Twice. Under a different surname. Did you think the nurses don't talk?

> *Kunle goes pale.*

BOARD CHAIRMAN The board has voted. Effective today, you're removed as Medical Director. *(beat)* You may keep your licence. That's for the medical council to decide. But you won't lead this hospital.

> *Silence. Kunle slowly stands. He looks around the table, at faces that once applauded him, and finds nobody looking back. He walks out. At her desk, Rita doesn't look up as he passes.*

ACT THREE

Learning to Live Again

SCENE 42 OF 53 · 41:39–42:21

Chloe Adeyemi Interiors

INT. SMALL OFFICE, WUSE, ABUJA — DAY — TWO YEARS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A modest office. A new sign on the door reads "CHLOE ADEYEMI INTERIORS." Fabric samples, sketches and one employee setting up a laptop. A happy CLIENT stands with Chloe.*

CLIENT This is exactly what I wanted. How long have you been doing this professionally?

CHLOE I trained years ago. I'm just finding my way back.

CLIENT Well, please don't stop. You're very good.

> *Her phone buzzes. Friday. 2:19 PM.*

EMMA
Madam CEO! How's the empire?

CHLOE
The empire has one employee and a printer that refuses to work.

EMMA
Every empire starts somewhere. Have you tried threatening the printer?

CHLOE
Emma! 😂 (beat) I wish you were here.

EMMA
Me too. One day.

SCENE 43 OF 53 · 42:21–43:56

The New Boss

INT. THE LAGOS HERALD — BOARDROOM, IKEJA — DAY — SAME YEAR

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A new Managing Director, MRS. FOLAKE DARAMOLA, sharp and no-nonsense, sits at the head of the table with a thick folder. Mr. Bayo sits stiffly beside her. Emma enters, nervous.*

MRS. DARAMOLA Sit down, Miss Williams. *(She opens the folder.)* I've spent my first month reading this newspaper's archive. Do you know what I found?

EMMA *(cautious)* No, ma.

MRS. DARAMOLA Forty-one stories with your research and somebody else's name on them. *(She looks at Bayo, who looks at the table.)* A notebook in your desk, tracking every unpaid salary in this building for three years, with names, dates and amounts. *(beat)* And the night-shift staff tell me that when Tayo's mother was in hospital, you paid the deposit from your own pocket.

EMMA *(quietly)* Somebody had to look after them, ma.

MRS. DARAMOLA Exactly. Somebody had to. *(She closes the folder.)* Mr. Adekola, you're relieved of your position as editor, effective today. *(Bayo leaves without a word.)* Miss Williams, you've been doing the job of a Human Resources department for ten years, for free. I'd like you to do it for a salary.

EMMA *(stunned)* Ma?

MRS. DARAMOLA Head of HR and Staff Welfare. Your first job is to pay everyone what they're owed. *(beat)* And your stories run under your own name from now on.

> *Emma walks out of the boardroom in a daze. In the corridor, Bisi is waiting. Emma grabs her and screams. Then she takes out her phone.*

EMMA
Chloe. CHLOE. They made me Head of HR. Me. The one who was nearly in the bin.

CHLOE
I'M SCREAMING IN A CLIENT'S KITCHEN. You kept writing the next one!

EMMA
Because a stranger told me to let them get tired first. (beat) They got tired, Chloe.

SCENE 44 OF 53 · 43:56–45:19

Now It's My Turn

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS / INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE, ABUJA — NIGHT — RONKE'S ANNIVERSARY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Emma sits in the dark with untouched takeaway. Today is one year since Ronke died. Her phone buzzes.*

CHLOE
You've been quiet all day. I know what today is. Talk to me.

EMMA
No jokes today. I keep thinking about that Thursday. I'm scared of the dark again, Chloe.

> *In Abuja, Chloe doesn't text back. She calls. Emma answers.*

CHLOE Emma. Are you safe right now?

EMMA *(a long breath)* Yes. I called Dr. Ifeoma this afternoon. Bisi is coming over.

CHLOE Good. *(beat)* Then tell me about her. Not how she died. Who she was.

EMMA *(surprised)* Nobody asks me that.

CHLOE I'm asking.

EMMA *(a small laugh through tears)* She named her wigs. All seven. Funmi, Shade, "Madam Senator"… She'd wear Madam Senator to chemo and make the nurses salute her. *(beat)* She used to call me "Emi." She said "Emma" was too serious for somebody who cries at adverts.

CHLOE *(softly)* She sounds like you.

EMMA *(crying now)* She was better than me.

CHLOE She was braver than the cancer. You're braver than the dark. *(beat)* You once told me I didn't have to earn kindness. That applies to you too, Emi.

> *Emma covers her mouth. Nobody has called her that in a year.*

EMMA Look at you giving me my own advice.

CHLOE Somebody has to. Your advice is expensive. *(beat)* Have you eaten?

EMMA No.

CHLOE Jollof or fried rice?

EMMA *(laughing through her tears)* Don't start.

SCENE 45 OF 53 · 45:19–45:51

Still Here

MONTAGE — LAGOS AND ABUJA — THE YEARS PASS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *FRIDAY, 8:07 AM.*

CHLOE
Still here ❤️

EMMA
Me too ❤️

> *ANOTHER FRIDAY, 6:41 PM.*

EMMA
Every single staff member got their full salary today. Every one. My first payday as HR.

CHLOE
MY GIRL!!!

> *ANOTHER FRIDAY, 10:12 PM.*

CHLOE
Today was difficult. Kunle missed the children's visit again. I don't feel like talking.

EMMA
That's okay. Sleep well, Chloe. I'm still here tomorrow.

SCENE 46 OF 53 · 45:51–46:35

"Coffee?"

INT. CONSTRUCTION SITE OFFICE, ABUJA — DAY — YEAR SEVEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Blueprints cover a table. TUNDE BALOGUN, an architect with kind eyes and a hard hat under his arm, finishes a meeting with Chloe.*

TUNDE That's the ceiling heights sorted. *(beat)* Would you like to get coffee?

CHLOE *(suspicious)* Coffee? As in a meeting?

TUNDE Not exactly. I was hoping for the kind where we talk about something other than ceiling heights.

CHLOE Tunde, before you say anything else, I've been married before. I have two children. And I'm not looking for someone to take over my life.

TUNDE *(smiling)* Good. I wouldn't know what to do with somebody else's life. I'm still trying to organise mine.

> *Chloe laughs despite herself.*

SCENE 47 OF 53 · 46:35–47:12

The Disagreement

INT. CHLOE ADEYEMI INTERIORS — DAY — MONTHS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Tunde and Chloe stand over a client's floor plan.*

TUNDE I'd put the kitchen window facing east.

CHLOE No. West. The client cooks in the evening. She wants the sunset.

TUNDE East gives morning light.

CHLOE *(folding her arms, bracing herself)* West, Tunde.

> *A long pause. Chloe watches his face very carefully.*

TUNDE *(nodding slowly)* West. You're right. You know the client better than I do.

> *He moves the window on the plan and goes back to work. Chloe stares at him, then quietly takes out her phone.*

CHLOE
Emma. I disagreed with him today.

EMMA
And?

CHLOE
And nothing happened. He just… agreed. And made me tea.

EMMA
(long pause) Chloe. That's what normal feels like.

SCENE 48 OF 53 · 47:12–47:55

"Excuse Me???"

INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE, ABUJA / INT. EMMA'S OFFICE, LAGOS — INTERCUT — FRIDAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

CHLOE
There's someone.

EMMA
EXCUSE ME???

CHLOE
Stop shouting through the phone.

EMMA
Name. Occupation. Criminal record. Favourite rice.

CHLOE
Tunde. Architect. No criminal record. And he likes both jollof and fried rice.

EMMA
A man with sense. Finally.

CHLOE
(after a pause) Emma, I'm scared of making another mistake.

EMMA
Then take your time. Watch how he treats you when you disagree. (beat) And watch how he treats your children when he thinks nobody is looking.

CHLOE
Ada says he's "boringly kind."

EMMA
(laughing) Marry him.

SCENE 49 OF 53 · 47:55–48:58

"Will You Come?"

INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE / EMMA'S OFFICE — FRIDAY, 2:19 PM — YEAR TEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A photo arrives on Emma's phone: Chloe's hand with an engagement ring.*

CHLOE
He asked.

EMMA
AND WHAT DID YOU SAY???

CHLOE
Yes, you ridiculous woman! 😂

EMMA
I'm screaming in my office. Bisi thinks I've been promoted again.

CHLOE
Emma. I need to ask you something.

EMMA
Anything.

CHLOE
Will you come to my wedding? (beat) I mean it. Ten years. I want us to finally meet.

> *Emma stares at the screen. Her eyes are wet.*

BISI *(leaning over)* What did she say?

EMMA She wants me to come. *(beat)* Bisi, what if I'm not who she imagines? Ten years of words. What if I walk in and I'm just… ordinary?

BISI Emma. You stood in our lobby and faced her husband for her. You're not ordinary. Go.

EMMA
What if you find out I'm a terrible woman who steals meat from other people's plates?

CHLOE
Emma.

EMMA
Yes?

CHLOE
Please come.

EMMA
(after a long pause) Of course I'll come.

SCENE 50 OF 53 · 48:58–49:51

Arrivals

INT. NNAMDI AZIKIWE AIRPORT, ABUJA — ARRIVALS — WEDDING DAY, 3:40 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Emma (45), in her emerald outfit with a gele box in her hand, stands frozen at the exit, on the phone with Bisi.*

BISI (ON PHONE) Emma, why are you still at the airport? The wedding starts at four!

EMMA Because my legs won't move, Bisi. *(beat)* Ten years. What if she looks at me and thinks, "That's her? That's all?"

BISI (ON PHONE) Emma Williams. You stood in a lobby and faced a man who pours rice on women. You can face a woman who loves you.

EMMA *(laughing nervously)* That's different. He didn't matter.

BISI (ON PHONE) And she does. That's why you're scared. *(beat)* Get in a taxi.

> *Emma takes a deep breath and walks out into the heat.*

EMMA *(to a taxi driver)* Asokoro, please. A wedding. *(beat)* And please drive slowly. I need time to stop shaking.

TAXI DRIVER *(grinning)* Madam, in Abuja traffic, you'll have plenty of time.

SCENE 51 OF 53 · 49:51–51:45

The Empty Chair

EXT. GARDEN WEDDING RECEPTION, ABUJA — EVENING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

Warm lights, white flowers, music and three hundred guests. Chloe (43), radiant in ivory, sits beside Tunde. Ada (17) and Tobi (14) are at the high table, and Halima and Mama Kunle sit near the front. At the front of the guest section, one chair has a little card on it: "RESERVED — EMMA." It's empty.

HALIMA *(leaning over, worried)* Chloe. Her flight landed two hours ago. She's still not here.

CHLOE *(checking her phone; no new message)* She'll come. *(beat)* She said she'd come.

MC And now, ladies and gentlemen, the bride would like to say a few words!

Chloe takes the microphone and looks once more at the empty chair.

CHLOE Thank you all for coming. And Tunde, thank you for loving the woman I am, not the woman you want me to become.

Applause.

CHLOE Ten years ago, I was standing in a kitchen with a fever, a crying child on my hip, and two bowls of rice in the fridge. And I was terrified. Because I couldn't remember whether my husband wanted jollof or fried rice. *(Soft laughter.)* You're laughing. I wasn't. In that house, a wrong answer had a price.

The guests go quiet.

CHLOE I sent the question to a number my husband had already thrown away. A dead number. *(beat)* And a stranger in Lagos answered. "Wrong receiver, but jollof rice with turkey sounds better."

Laughter, gentler now.

CHLOE She answered the next Friday. And the next. For ten years. When I told her I was afraid in my own home, she didn't laugh at me. She asked if I was safe. When my husband deleted her from my phone, she wrote back anyway. When he threatened her, she told him to come. *(beat)* And he went.

Murmurs through the crowd.

CHLOE She didn't save me. She couldn't. But every Friday, she reminded me that I was worth saving. *(Her voice cracks.)* And here's the part you won't believe. I have never seen her face.

Gasps.

CHLOE Her name is Emma Williams. *(She looks at the empty chair.)* And she promised she'd be here.

> *Silence. Nobody stands. The empty chair stays empty. Chloe's smile begins to falter. Tunde quietly takes her hand. Then, on the table beside her bouquet, her phone lights up.*

SCENE 52 OF 53 · 51:45–53:39

"Still Here"

EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION — CONTINUOUS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

EMMA
Still here ❤️

Chloe gasps. She looks up. At the very back, behind the last row, by the gate, a woman in an emerald-green gele and outfit rises slowly from a plastic chair among the drivers and late arrivals. She is crying and smiling.

EMMA *(calling out)* Chloe?

CHLOE *(her hand over her mouth)* Emma?

EMMA *(through tears)* I sat at the back. I was scared you'd be disappointed. *(beat)* And you still haven't learned to cook the right rice.

The whole reception bursts into laughter and applause. Chloe gathers her dress and runs down the aisle. Emma walks toward her. They stop one step apart. Ten years. First time.

CHLOE You came.

EMMA Of course I came.

CHLOE *(crying)* I don't even know what to say.

EMMA Well, that's a first.

They burst out laughing and throw their arms around each other. They hold on for a long time, rocking. Then Emma pulls back.

CHLOE Thank you.

EMMA For what?

CHLOE For answering.

EMMA *(shaking her head, tears falling)* No, Chloe. You don't understand. *(beat)* The afternoon your first text came, I'd just woken up from the worst night of my life. I didn't want to be here anymore. *(beat)* And a stranger asked me about rice.

Chloe stares at her. She knew about the dark nights. She never knew about that afternoon.

EMMA You didn't text the wrong number, Chloe. *(beat)* You texted the right one. On the right day.

They hold each other again, tighter.

Ada runs over and wraps her arms around Emma.

ADA You're Aunty Friday! You're the secret message!

EMMA *(laughing)* I suppose I am!

> *Tunde approaches with a warm smile and offers his hand.*

TUNDE So you're the famous Emma.

EMMA And you're the man who likes both kinds of rice?

TUNDE Guilty.

EMMA *(shaking his hand)* Then we'll get along. *(leaning in, half joking, half not)* Treat her well. I know where Ikeja is, and I know where Abuja is.

TUNDE *(laughing)* Noted, madam.

> *Mama Kunle comes forward and takes Emma's hands.*

MAMA KUNLE You faced my son. *(beat)* Thank you for doing what I was too afraid to do for thirty years.

> *Chloe goes back to the microphone, still holding Emma's hand.*

CHLOE One last thing. If you're living in a house where you're afraid, please talk to someone you trust. Accept help. And if someone ever reaches out to you, even by mistake, don't underestimate what it means to answer. *(She looks at Emma.)* Ten years ago, one dead number sent my message to the wrong person. *(beat)* And somehow, it reached exactly the person I needed. *(beat)* And she tells me it reached exactly the person who needed me.

> *The guests rise in applause. Emma wipes her eyes.*

SCENE 53 OF 53 · 53:39 — END

Whatever You Want

INT. CHLOE AND TUNDE'S KITCHEN, ABUJA — FRIDAY, 2:17 PM — ONE WEEK LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Sunlight, big windows and soft music. A happy, lived-in kitchen. Tunde walks in, kisses the top of Chloe's head and opens the fridge.*

TUNDE Darling, what are we eating tonight?

CHLOE I haven't decided.

TUNDE Anything you make, I'll eat. *(He grabs an apple and leaves, humming.)*

> *Chloe stands alone at the counter. She opens the fridge. One bowl of jollof rice. One bowl of fried rice. She smiles. 2:19 PM. Her phone buzzes.*

EMMA
Happy Friday, Rice Woman! What's cooking? 😂

CHLOE
I haven't decided. Jollof or fried?

EMMA
Whatever YOU want, Chloe.

> *Chloe stares at the words.*

CHLOE *(whispering)* Whatever I want.

> *She looks out of the big window at the garden, where Ada and Tobi are laughing with Tunde. Then she types.*

CHLOE
Jollof rice with turkey. Obviously ❤️

EMMA
FINALLY. Ten years to learn 😂❤️

> *Chloe laughs out loud, a free laugh, in her own kitchen.*

"Sometimes, the people who change our lives arrive without an introduction."
— THE WRONG NUMBER

If you are struggling or feel unsafe, please talk to someone you trust today, or contact a doctor or local helpline. You are not alone.

END

THE END

One dead number. One unexpected friendship. Ten years of showing up.

↑ Back to all scenes